C2 Listening

Connected speech: linking, weak forms and elision

Understand natural, fast English by recognising how sounds join, shrink and disappear between words.

In natural speech, words are not separated by pauses. Sounds link together, small grammar words lose their vowels, and some sounds vanish. Knowing these patterns helps you hear words you already know but fail to recognise at speed.

Feature	What happens	Written / How it sounds
Linking	A final consonant joins the next vowel	*turn it off → tur-ni-toff*
Weak forms	Grammar words lose their stress	*a cup of tea → a cup-uh tea; for you → fuh you*
Elision	A /t/ or /d/ disappears between consonants	*next week → nex week; handbag → hanbag*
Assimilation	A sound changes to suit the next one	*ten pounds → tem pounds; did you → didja*
Contractions	Auxiliaries shorten	*I would have → I'd've; you are not → you're not / you aren't*

Listen

Listen for stressed words. Content words such as nouns, main verbs and adjectives keep their stress. Catch those first, then let grammar fill the gaps: *GET a CHANCE to LOOK at the proPOsal.*

Common mistake. Trying to hear every word clearly. Native speakers don't pronounce every word fully, so listen for meaning in chunks, not single words.

Practice

Listen at normal speed first, then use the transcript.

1. How is "Did you" likely to sound at the start?
2. What is the full form of "I'd've"?
3. In "last night", which sound is likely to disappear?
4. In "Most of it's fine", how do "of" and "it's" link?
5. Why is the speaker worried about the budget?

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Transcript

Did you get a chance to look at the proposal? I'd've sent it sooner, but I couldn't get hold of the figures till last night. Most of it's fine, I think. The only thing I'm not sure about is the budget for next quarter. We've asked for a lot more than last time, and they're bound to question it. If you've got a minute this afternoon, could we go through it together? Just let me know what time suits you, and I'll book a room.

Answers

1. "Didja" (assimilation of /d/ + /j/)
2. I would have
3. The /t/ at the end of "last": "las night"
4. The /v/ of "of" joins the vowel of "it's": "o-vit's".
5. They asked for much more than last time, so it will probably be questioned.